

The rise of authoritarian informationalism: escalating surveillance, manipulation, and control

Lisa Garbe & Seraphine F. Maerz

To cite this article: Lisa Garbe & Seraphine F. Maerz (2026) The rise of authoritarian informationalism: escalating surveillance, manipulation, and control, *Democratization*, 33:1, 1-18, DOI: [10.1080/13510347.2025.2579105](https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2025.2579105)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2025.2579105>



Published online: 18 Dec 2025.



Submit your article to this journal [↗](#)



Article views: 4064



View related articles [↗](#)



View Crossmark data [↗](#)

INTRODUCTION



The rise of authoritarian informationalism: escalating surveillance, manipulation, and control

Lisa Garbe^a and Seraphine F. Maerz^b

^aWZB Berlin, Berlin, Germany; ^bSchool of Social and Political Sciences, Faculty of Arts, The University of Melbourne, Melbourne, Australia

ABSTRACT

The past decade has witnessed a transformation in the study of authoritarian governance, with increasing attention paid to how digital technologies reshape strategies of regime survival. While initial research focused on individual digital strategies like censorship, internet shutdowns, or online propaganda, emerging scholarship conceptualizes the broader, meta-level effects of digitalization on authoritarian tactics. Building on these advancements, we introduce the concept of authoritarian informationalism to capture the evolving interplay between analogue and digital strategies of surveillance, manipulation, and information control. This approach emphasizes the centrality of information flows in contemporary political power, highlighting a shift from visible, repressive coercion towards more covert, preventive, and targeted forms of digital repression. Authoritarian informationalism is characterized by (1) an expansion of actors – from states to private entities and individuals; (2) increased precision, moving from reactive to pre-emptive and fine-grained control; and (3) broader scope, extending from local and national to transnational domains and across regime types. Importantly, this transformation blurs traditional boundaries between autocracies and democracies, as well as between domestic and international spheres. Our framework and the contributions to this Special Issue bridge empirical analyses of digital tools and theoretical debates on authoritarian resilience, illustrating both the extension of authoritarian informational power and the emergence of new vulnerabilities and dependencies.

ARTICLE HISTORY Received 18 September 2025; Accepted 20 October 2025

Introduction

Over the past decade, empirical studies of modern authoritarianism have increasingly examined digital strategies and their effects. Research spans a wide spectrum – from blunt and overt measures such as complete internet shutdowns and censorship,¹ to more covert and sophisticated forms of filtering and manipulating online content,² and the targeted monitoring of individuals.³

More recently, scholars have begun to investigate the broader, meta-level implications of this expanding digital toolkit for authoritarian resilience. These contributions all share a common goal: to conceptualize how digital technologies complement, substitute, or transform existing strategies of authoritarian survival. In

CONTACT Seraphine F. Maerz  seraphine.maerz@unimelb.edu.au

© 2025 Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group

doing so, they aim to equip empirical researchers with more rigorous frameworks for assessing the role of digitalization in strengthening as well as undermining authoritarian rule. For instance, Keremoğlu and Weidmann⁴ conceptualize different layers of the internet that are subject to manipulation and control, stressing the importance of understanding how digital tactics interact with one another and how they reinforce, complement, or substitute for analogue strategies. Earl et al.⁵ focus on digital repression and categorize different forms of it. Others highlight the central role of information management in autocracies⁶ and conceptualize how digital practices silence and disable access to information⁷ and discuss broader transformations in this core area.⁸ Collectively, these contributions provide researchers with more rigorous conceptual tools, allowing systematic analysis of how digitalization may reinforce or undermine authoritarianism, and offering new directions for empirical investigation.

Building on these insights, we see digital authoritarianism not as a new phenomenon but rather as a transformation of existing tactics through the use of digital – and increasingly also AI-driven – technologies. To capture this shift, we introduce the concept of authoritarian informationalism, which emphasizes the important role of controlling information flows in contemporary authoritarian regimes, but also in democracies and transnational contexts. Authoritarian informationalism refers to the effective interplay between offline and online tactics to escalate the surveillance, manipulation, and control of information to the central mode of political power. Unlike traditional forms of authoritarianism, which rested heavily on overt and coercive forms of repression, authoritarian informationalism thrives on covert repression which is more targeted and less visible but, importantly, not necessarily less severe for those affected. Crucially, this logic transcends the classical boundaries of regime type and frequently operates across borders. We propose that the transformation of traditional authoritarian strategies in the digital era unfolds along three key dimensions: (1) Actors; shifting from monopolistic state control to the involvement of private actors and even individuals, (2) Precision; evolving from reactive and blunt measures to preventive and fine-grained forms of control, and (3) Scope; expanding from local domains to global arenas and across regime types. Considered together, we believe that changes in these dimensions lead to a broader transformation in the logic of authoritarian rule.

Thinking in terms of these dimensions is not only conceptually clarifying but also of practical relevance for empirical scholarship. It encourages researchers to move beyond cataloguing individual digital tools and instead to ask how specific technologies or tactics map onto broader changes in actors, precision, and scope and with what consequences. This perspective can guide case selection, help in comparing across regimes, and sharpen measurement strategies – for example, by distinguishing between state-led propaganda versus individual pro-regime influencers, between reactive versus preventive censorship, or between domestic versus transnational information collection, processing, manipulation, and control. In short, the framework provides a bridge between the fast-moving landscape of digital technologies and the more enduring theoretical debates on authoritarian resilience.

Our Special Issue brings together research that illuminates how information management in autocracies is being transformed in terms of actors involved, precision, and scope. It contributes to broader debates on how digital tools complement or reinforce established analogue strategies. Collectively, the studies demonstrate that digitalization extends authoritarian informational power without changing its core objectives. At a

meta level, the implication is that digital technologies strengthen authoritarian resilience: they broaden the reach of surveillance, increase the sophistication of propaganda and manipulation, and lower the costs of pre-empting dissent. At the same time, they generate new dependencies on transnational infrastructures and non-state actors, creating vulnerabilities that may paradoxically constrain authoritarian control.

Authoritarian informationalism

Guriev and Treisman⁹ coined the term informational autocrats to describe a new type of authoritarianism that relies less on overt repression and ideology and more on manipulating information to maintain power. Instead of terrorizing the entire population with bloody repression, informational autocrats work on shaping public opinion and controlling the narrative so that the population believes in the legitimacy of the regime. Instead of cultivating a discourse of threat and fear by publicly jailing or killing regime opponents, informational autocrats try to conceal violence and opt for public communication strategies that emphasize economic performance and national pride to build legitimacy. Instead of imposing a rigid ideology onto the masses, informational autocrats intervene surgically and want to appear as pragmatic and competent rulers. As Guriev and Treisman illustrate, many of these new informational autocrats came into power via elections and want to maintain a facade of democracy while they covertly transform political institutions.¹⁰

While Guriev and Treisman focus on political regimes, the term “informationalism” – originating in sociology – more broadly describes the revolution of how information is produced, processed, and distributed in the digital age.¹¹ Castells coined the term to capture the transformation of industrialism and capitalism into a new mode of development that is based on the generation and processing of information rather than the production of material goods. Computers and digital communication technologies drive this revolution; however, informationalism is not just about technology but about a broader social and economic transformation that affects all aspects of society.¹²

Already in 2010, Jiang¹³ introduced the term authoritarian informationalism in the context of China to describe the regime’s emerging internet policies and regulatory model that combines elements of capitalism, authoritarianism, Confucianism, and informationalism. As per Jiang, the Chinese model of authoritarian informationalism is characterized by a strong state presence in the digital realm, with the government actively shaping the development of the internet and using it as a tool for social control. At the same time, the Chinese government has embraced market-oriented reforms and allowed for the growth of private enterprises in the digital sector.¹⁴ This combination of state control and market-oriented reforms has created a distinctive model of internet governance that is increasingly influential globally and also imitated by other authoritarian regimes.¹⁵

We build on these works and suggest to extend the concept of authoritarian informationalism beyond China to capture a broader cross-regime logic of rule that emphasizes the surveillance, manipulation, and control of information as a central mode of political power. Similar to Guriev and Treisman,¹⁶ we argue that unlike traditional forms of authoritarianism, which rested heavily on repression and coercion, authoritarian informationalism relies on subtle techniques: online influence operations which go beyond disinformation to artificially amplify regime support,¹⁷ strategic agenda-setting, algorithmic filtering, and the monopolization of digital infrastructures. In

addition, this new concept helps to better understand how the transformation of authoritarianism is not just about new forms of digital repression but also includes sophisticated techniques of manipulating public discourse and shaping perceptions of truth and legitimacy. In this regard, we rely on Glasius¹⁸ practice-based definition of authoritarianism which cuts across different regime types and focuses on practices that subvert accountability by disabling access to (reliable, not manipulated) information and citizens' voice. Apart from that, we illustrate three key features of authoritarian informationalism that highlight how this new concept goes beyond existing notions of digital authoritarianism and therefore helps to better understand the transformation of authoritarian rule in the digital age.

First, digital authoritarianism is not a new phenomenon but rather a transformation of existing authoritarian tactics through the use of digital technologies. We refer to this as authoritarian informationalism to highlight that central to this transformation is the fight over monopolizing and controlling information flows. We do not call it digital authoritarianism because the term suggests that digital technologies are the defining feature of contemporary authoritarianism. While digital technologies are important tools for today's authoritarian regimes, we argue that the phenomenon cuts across digital and analogue realms and that it is the interplay between and effective merger of offline and online tactics that is crucial to understanding the transformation of traditional authoritarian strategies and brings new actors into play.

Second, earlier work has argued that informational autocrats opt for less violent and more subtle forms of control.¹⁹ We argue that digitalization has transformed traditional authoritarian strategies of maintaining power and control in ways that make them more preventive, targeted, and less visible. However, while the quantity of overt, physical repression may decline, the quality of repression changes in ways that make it more sophisticated, data-driven, and difficult to detect but not necessarily less severe for the affected individuals. This has important implications for how we understand and respond to authoritarian styles of ruling in the digital age.

Third, authoritarian informationalism reaches beyond the boundaries of single regime types and countries. The observed practices of surveilling, manipulating, and controlling information ecosystems are not confined to autocracies but are increasingly creeping into democratic politics as well. The transnational dimension of authoritarian informationalism is also important, as authoritarian leaders seek to influence governance elsewhere.²⁰

In the following, we illustrate how authoritarian informationalism transforms traditional authoritarian strategies of surveillance, manipulation, and control along three dimensions: (1) Actors; from state to private, from organizations to individuals, (2) precision; from reaction to prevention, from blunt to fine-grained control, and (3) scope; from local to global and across regime types. Table 1 provides an overview of these dimensions and their implications for the transformation of authoritarian rule.

Surveillance

The landscape of actors involved in modern surveillance has diversified and expanded considerably. Beyond authoritarian states themselves, a network of private companies – ranging from providers of internet infrastructure over social media platforms to firms specializing in spyware or facial recognition technology – play significant roles in data collection and analytics. These actors shape not only the availability of information but

Table 1. Dimensions of authoritarian informationalism.

Dimension	Surveillance	Manipulation	Control	Transformation
Actors	Private firms provide surveillance tools (e.g. Pegasus from NSO Group)	Individuals (e.g. influencers, bloggers) act as narrative multipliers	Private corporations, platforms, and ISPs enforce moderation and access limits, often at state behest	From state to private; from organizational to individual
Precision	Intrusive spyware enables surveillance of individuals (even abroad); big-data analytics identify potential threats early	AI and algorithmic tools allow tailored, micro-targeted manipulation of opinions and behaviours	Fine-grained filtering of content; selective, invisible censorship	From reaction to prevention, from blunt to fine-grained control
Scope	Cross-border collection, including targeting diaspora communities	Automated campaigns (bots, trolls, deepfakes) expand manipulation across regime types and across borders	Internet shutdowns or censorship for entire regions, countries, segments of population	From local to global and across regime types

also the ability to connect disparate sources and analyse them in powerful ways. Examples include Guinea where the government demanded private-owned internet service providers to redirect user traffic to a central hub, enabling the telecommunications regulator to monitor private communications at scale.²¹ The United Arab Emirates was among the first authoritarian states to deploy spyware such as the Pegasus tool developed by the Israeli firm NSO Group, using it to hack the phones of dissidents, journalists, lawyers, and activists around the world.²² As Deibert notes, with this kind of spyware, “targeted espionage against civil society [...] both near and far are easier to undertake than ever before.”²³ The role of private firms in enabling such practices – through the sharing of personal data and the surveillance of individuals’ devices – raises pressing questions about the complicity of non-state actors in repression, as well as the urgent need for regulatory oversight and accountability.²⁴

Digitalization fundamentally transforms the precision and scope of the collection, surveillance and processing of information by governments. The dramatic reduction in the cost of data collection enables these regimes to gather vast quantities of information with unprecedented granularity and scope. Critically, these technologies address one of the core dilemmas authoritarian rulers face: citizens’ reluctance to share their true preferences, leaving the rulers uncertain about the actual level of support they have.²⁵ While new technologies enable the constant monitoring of entire populations and the early detection of critical voices, they also make it possible to intrusively spy on targeted individuals – even beyond a country’s traditional borders.

To collect information about its citizens at large, governments use various new tools that improve the scale of traditional ways of monitoring.²⁶ For instance, by deploying e-government platforms to deliver administrative services online, governments not only streamline bureaucratic processes and foster a façade of transparency and citizen participation, but also systematically capture detailed data on citizens’ preferences and behaviours at scale. As shown in four post-Soviet cases, such digital initiatives are strategically leveraged to broaden popular support and legitimize authoritarian rule.²⁷ Even more intrusive is China’s Social Credit System (SCS), which has been

described as a form of “big data-enabled surveillance.”²⁸ The system aggregates vast amounts of information – from individuals’ social media activity to their movements and credit histories – in order to predict behaviour and ultimately reward or punish it. Not only in China, but mass surveillance technologies such as facial recognition are increasingly deployed to monitor populations across the globe. Though often framed as tools for counter-terrorism or improving access to state services,²⁹ facial recognition systems have been re-purposed across diverse contexts – from the United States³⁰ to Hong Kong –³¹ to undermine anonymity in protests and assembly, eroding essential civil liberties.³² Often, the very presence of such technologies acts as a deterrent, discouraging citizens from voting or engaging in collective action due to fear of surveillance and repression.³³

Once governments have detected individuals they deem threatening to their rule, they are able to use novel and sophisticated spyware to monitor and track specific groups or high-risk individuals with minimal resources, effectively lowering surveillance costs. For instance, Qin et al.³⁴ analyse large amount of data from Chinese social media platform Weibo, showing that the central government actively monitors online conversations to detect and punish corruption among lower-tier officials. This monitoring not only reinforces accountability but also facilitates cooptation strategies that are critical to authoritarian resilience.³⁵ Beyond domestic monitoring, regimes extend their reach transnationally, exploiting global data flows to surveil diaspora communities and target dissidents abroad with harassment or repression.³⁶ Michaelsen and Anstis³⁷ illustrate how these new forms of more covert and less visible repression beyond national borders severely impact the lives of diaspora communities.³⁸

In sum, the transformations in actors, precision, and scope of information collection significantly enhance states’ capacity for surveillance. The expanded scope allows for mass data gathering across entire populations and geographic boundaries, while improvements in precision enable more granular and accurate monitoring of individuals and specific groups. Meanwhile, the involvement of a diverse range of actors – including state agencies, private spyware firms, technology providers, and global social media platforms – facilitates access to advanced tools and transnational data flows. Together, these developments greatly increase the volume, variety, and detail of information that governments can acquire, strengthening their overall capacity for comprehensive and targeted data collection.

Manipulation

With the rise of authoritarian informationalism, the actors involved in information manipulation are diversifying. Beyond state-run media, individual users and partisan influencers can now amplify regime narratives, blurring the line between orchestrated propaganda and grassroots expression.³⁹ For instance, Osmundsen et al.,⁴⁰ drawing on a sample of US-American Twitter users, show that individuals who report hating their political opponents are important amplifiers of fake news and derogatory content. At the same time, social media companies play a problematic role: their algorithms, designed to maximize engagement and revenue, boost polarizing and manipulative content.⁴¹ For example, during Anti-Maduro protests in Venezuela in 2014, Venezuelan legislators used Twitter to spread competing narratives to efficiently manage the conflict.⁴² This convergence of state, individual, and corporate actors complicates accountability, requiring responses that address not only government censorship but

also platform governance and user participation in spreading narratives in support of authoritarian rule.

Contemporary information manipulation has expanded dramatically in precision and scope. Where regimes once relied primarily on centralized outlets like television or radio, digital technologies now enable them to “flood” the internet with regime-approved and increasingly AI-generated narratives while drowning out opposition voices⁴³ and making it increasingly difficult to discern fact from fiction.⁴⁴ This strategy enables authoritarian regimes to shape public opinion, bolster legitimacy, and reduce threats to regime stability. As Roberts⁴⁵ notes, this strategy raises the costs for users, who must spend more time and energy to locate reliable information and distinguish it from false or biased content. Experimental studies further demonstrate how challenging it has become for individuals to separate fact from fiction, propaganda and disinformation from journalism, thereby underscoring how information manipulation increasingly blurs the truth.⁴⁶

With respect to scope, the deployment of bots, trolls, and, more recently, AI-based tools such as deepfakes illustrates the extensive capacity of digitally mediated mechanisms to disseminate and amplify narratives. Case studies highlight how bots and trolls play a central role in disseminating propaganda and disinformation. In Russia, for example, bots were mobilized to counter large online and offline protests⁴⁷ and to campaign against opposition leader Alexei Navalny.⁴⁸ Authoritarian actors also deploy such tools beyond their own borders. During the 2016 US presidential campaign, Russian trolls amplified partisan messages to bolster Republican support⁴⁹ while simultaneously spreading apolitical content to divert public attention from politics.⁵⁰ Another tool that recently gained more attention is deepfakes – AI-generated hyper realistic fake images or videos – that have been used to manipulate individuals’ opinions. For example, during India’s 2019 elections, several deepfake videos impersonating prominent candidates went viral, casting doubts on the candidates’ credibility.⁵¹ Deepfakes are also used by several far-right groups and parties in Western democracies to spread disinformation and manipulate public opinion. In Germany, for example, the far-right party AfD spread deepfake videos to manipulate public opinion and influence electoral outcomes during the most recent elections in February 2024.⁵² Deepfakes have become a tool increasingly used in the context of elections in recent years and can be harmful not only to individuals’ reputation but also to social institutions like trust.⁵³

Apart from the possibility to spread messages at scale, digital means also allow for automatically personalizing content in a way that it caters to specific groups in society. For instance, during Taipeh’s mayoral race in 2014, campaigners for independent candidate Ko Wen-je used crawler bots to gather data from Facebook pages, classify users into interest groups, and send tailored messages to different groups encouraging them to vote for their candidate.⁵⁴ What makes computational propaganda particularly effective is that it allows for identifying and targeting the small number of individuals who are most susceptible to manipulation.⁵⁵ Generative AI further amplifies these dynamics by enhancing the targeting and persuasiveness of fake news, disinformation, and propaganda, ensuring the “right” narratives reach this group of the most susceptible individuals. Combined with bots and sockpuppets that divert attention and discredit opponents, these technologies allow for far more refined manipulation than the broad, one-size-fits-all broadcasts of the past.

Control

Controlling information has been transformed by major shifts in the actor landscape. Authoritarian regimes once depended mainly on state-run media and government censors to control information flows, but the rise of digital technologies has created a far more fragmented and multi-layered landscape of actors. Today, private firms provide much of the infrastructure necessary to access the internet,⁵⁶ making them central to the implementation of online censorship and shutdowns. At the same time, the proliferation of content providers and platforms complicates the field of information control. While some states operate their own platforms – most prominently, China with platforms like WeChat, Weibo or Red Note – many authoritarian regimes rely on international platforms such as Facebook, X, or TikTok, making it more difficult to control and take down content. This shift has amplified contestation between governments, global platforms, and civil society over who decides the boundaries of legitimate information – sometimes resulting in outright platform bans,⁵⁷ data localization laws,⁵⁸ and pressure on platforms to comply with local censorship requests or risk being blocked.

Digitalization has greatly enhanced both the scope and precision of information control. Traditional approaches – often reactive and blunt – are giving way to more proactive, preventive strategies that suppress information even before it is created. States can now block entire platforms, specific domains, or even individual posts and accounts, often within seconds. In China, for instance, “keyword blocking” automatically prevents users from posting content that contains banned words.⁵⁹ Worldwide, governments strategically deploy internet shutdowns during contested events such as elections or protests to disrupt potential mobilization.⁶⁰ Such shutdowns, whether nationwide or targeted at specific regions or demographics, can significantly disrupt information flows at the most critical moments.⁶¹ The ability to disconnect entire communication networks swiftly and selectively empowers authorities to control precisely who receives – and who is denied – access to information, at what times and in which locations.

Moreover, digitalization enables regimes to exercise sophisticated control over the content itself. Advanced filtering and censorship mechanisms allow for the shaping of public discourse by controlling which content becomes visible, effectively steering narratives and silencing sensitive topics without overtly shutting down entire information channels.⁶² In China, for instance, censorship is highly selective: posts that criticize government performance may remain online, while those likely to inspire collective action are removed.⁶³ Targeted cyberattacks on opposition websites supplement these efforts, effectively incapacitating critical voices in a focused and often less visible way.⁶⁴

However, even as technological innovations expand states’ capacities for control, the growing diversity of actors involved in the digital information ecosystem – particularly global platforms and private infrastructure providers – complicates the exercise of such control. This increasingly fragmented environment has prompted many authoritarian governments to supplement technical measures with legal and regulatory instruments. Sweeping “fake news” and cybersecurity laws⁶⁵ serve not only to criminalize dissent but also to reassert state authority over the transnational flow of information, embedding censorship within the legal architecture of governance itself.

Overall, the changes in precision, scope, and actors involved in information management contribute to a transformation in the logic of authoritarian rule. Rather than relying primarily on overt propaganda and coercive censorship designed to project regime strength, digitalization enables more subtle and persuasive forms of influence aimed at shaping perceptions of truth and legitimacy. Digital platforms blur the boundaries between state and non-state messaging, as influencers, trolls, and seemingly independent accounts amplify regime narratives. This diffusion complicates attribution, lowers the visibility of state involvement, and makes fabricated information flows more difficult to detect and counter.

At the same time, digitalization does not solely strengthen authoritarian control – it also equips activists, journalists, and human rights organizations with new tools to document repression and mobilize international pressure.⁶⁶ These dynamics reinforce a broader shift from blunt repression towards more preventive, fine-grained strategies of control.⁶⁷ By enabling regimes to anticipate and pre-empt dissent, digital technologies reduce the need for overt coercion, allowing authoritarian rulers to maintain power while minimizing visible repression. However, this transformation also raises significant challenges for detection and accountability, as more covert forms of control become harder to identify and counter.

The contributions to this Special Issue

The seven articles in this Special Issue investigate the transformation of traditional authoritarian strategies and illustrate how authoritarian regimes use digital technologies to enhance surveillance, manipulation, and control. The contributions cover a range of contexts, including Iran, Russia, Belarus, Ukraine, Thailand, Saudi Arabia, and various African countries. Collectively, they examine the three aspects of authoritarian informationalism: First, the shift from state to private actors and from organizations to individuals is illustrated by how modern authoritarian rule relies on individual regime supporters,⁶⁸ how individuals support internet voting despite its vulnerabilities,⁶⁹ how foreign direct investment is used as a form of authoritarian collaboration to develop digital infrastructure,⁷⁰ and how inviting private firms into the digital economy can also constrain authoritarianism.⁷¹ Second, the shift from mass to targeted and less visible repression is shown by how online smear campaigns reinforce judicial harassment,⁷² and how preventive internet regulations restrict digital rights.⁷³ Third, the shift of authoritarian strategies from local to global levels and across regime types is highlighted by how authoritarian practices are also applied by democratically elected governments.⁷⁴ Below, we briefly summarize the main findings of each article and highlight how they contribute to our understanding of authoritarian informationalism.

The contribution by Schmidt-Feuerheerd⁷⁵ draws on approximately 100 interviews with nationalist and patriotic journalists, intellectuals, and influencers in Saudi Arabia to examine the phenomenon of how private individuals contribute to regime stability through what the author calls collaborative authoritarianism. Schmidt-Feuerheerd finds that individuals who identify as regime supporters actively police dissenters on Twitter, generating an impression of societal consensus that bolsters the legitimacy of the regime. This is particularly notable because, unlike closed authoritarian regimes such as China, which operate their own social media platforms, many authoritarian governments allow – and rely on – Western-based platforms like X and Meta,

where they cannot directly control content. Instead, the regime depends on its individual and vigilante supporters to indirectly shape a narrative favourable to the incumbent. This is possible because the algorithms on these platforms incentivize mob attacks, thereby reinforcing the “impression of consensus about what society ‘thinks’.”⁷⁶ Overall, the article illustrates how authoritarian regimes can leverage individual regime supporters on global digital platforms to create a sense of legitimacy and suppress dissent, even in the absence of direct control over the platforms themselves.

In their article, Burkhardt and Dollbaum⁷⁷ use evidence from six surveys conducted in Russia, Belarus, and Ukraine to show that voters who support the incumbent are more likely to endorse internet voting despite widespread concerns about its fairness under authoritarian regimes. This is concerning because popular backing of an “instrument that potentially makes fraud easier and less detectable”⁷⁸ risks obscuring the inherent vulnerabilities of digital voting and may contribute to normalizing a practice fraught with risks. Without rigorous scrutiny of its impartiality, the unchecked expansion of internet voting could undermine electoral integrity and ultimately strengthen the legitimacy of authoritarian rule by masking fraud and manipulation. The contribution of Burkhardt and Dollbaum⁷⁹ is another example of the shift from state to private actors and from organizations to individuals, as it illustrates how individual voters can contribute to the legitimization of authoritarian practices.

Conduit’s⁸⁰ article illustrates the shift from state to private actors from a political economy perspective. By looking into the case of Iran, Conduit highlights three mechanisms through which the longstanding economic context of the country enables and, importantly, also constrains authoritarian informationalism, illustrating crucial continuities between how the regime traditionally tried to control the state’s economy and how it also tries to use the economy to sustain its informational power in the digital age. First, economic tools are used to incentivize private actors to cooperate with the regime such as via discounted local internet data and industry subsidies for firms that comply with state demands.⁸¹ Second, economic tools are used to coerce private firms and the population into using technology in the regime-prescribed way. For example, VPN users are punished and using foreign internet sites is more costly.⁸² Third, by inviting private firms into the digital economy, the regime becomes vulnerable to their interests, risking their disapproval. For example, the frequent internet shutdowns Iran implemented in order to suppress dissidence inadvertently eroded the support from these private actors as it counteracted their interests. Overall, this contribution highlights that while the primary goal of authoritarian informationalism is to maintain power, the shift from state to private actors providing access to information is coming with new vulnerabilities which also constrain (digital) authoritarian rule.

Garbe et al.⁸³ investigate the conditions under which authoritarian states accept foreign direct investment (FDI) to develop their digital infrastructure. They find that while authoritarian regimes are generally cautious about allowing foreign private companies to operate in their digital space, they are more likely to accept FDI from countries with similar political regimes when their rule relies on a substantial amount of offline repression. They further illustrate that authoritarian regimes which collaborate with foreign companies from other autocracies are more likely to expand their repression online. The article is an example of the shift from state to private actors, as it highlights the increasing importance of private actors in sustaining authoritarian rule, and, crucially, how corporate actors from autocratic regimes can also help

reinforce and expand authoritarianism beyond their own borders, illustrating the shift from mass to targeted and less visible repression, as it shows how authoritarian regimes use digital technologies to enhance their traditional forms of repression.

The article by Sombatpoonsiri et al.⁸⁴ explores how online smear campaigns reinforce judicial harassment, particularly during Thailand's 2020–2021 anti-establishment protests.⁸⁵ It highlights how this subtler form of repression – targeting opposition members, journalists, and activists through the courts – is effectively complemented by coordinated online influence operations. These campaigns serve to legitimize judicial actions, framing them as justified and necessary measures, thereby strengthening the overall impact of state repression. The article illustrates how the regime effectively combines offline and online tactics to suppress dissent, making it an example of the shift from mass to targeted and less visible repression.

Schumann's⁸⁶ article is an example of the shift from reaction to prevention, as it illustrates how authoritarian regimes use non-digital measures to prevent online dissent. Specifically, it analyzes when states transform existing legal capacity into tools for controlling digital information spaces. Such legal control of the internet is justified as cybersecurity or privacy protection, yet it often enables punishment of online expression and expanded surveillance. Drawing on original data on internet legislation across sub-Saharan African countries, the article shows that governments are more likely to enact legislation that restricts online freedoms preventively, outside the spotlight of political events. Rather than domestic or regional unrest, the regional prevalence of legal internet controls predicts the enactment of such restrictive regulations. When governments use traditional state control mechanisms, especially legal instruments, to regulate information online, regional norms appear to shape the boundaries of permissible civil and political rights restrictions. This is particularly important in the Global South, where many countries are still developing their frameworks for internet governance and are looking not only to the European Union but increasingly to autocratic peers for guidance on policy matters.

The article by Maerz⁸⁷ looks into how practices of digital authoritarianism are creeping into democracies. The author examines how democratic governments use digital technologies to surveil, manipulate, and control information in ways that go beyond what is necessary for national security or public safety. The article finds that democratic governments increasingly adopt practices of digital authoritarianism, such as official disinformation in social media, the abuse of defamation and copyright laws, surveilling social media, and government access to personal data on the internet. This is particularly concerning because, as Maerz⁸⁸ finds, it undermines core democratic institutions of democratic accountability, civil liberties, and freedom of expression.

Conclusion

The contributions to this Special Issue illustrate how digital technologies are transforming traditional authoritarian strategies of surveillance, manipulation, and control. The articles demonstrate how the actor landscape is diversifying, with private firms and individual regime supporters playing increasingly important roles in sustaining authoritarian rule. They also highlight the complex interplay between offline and online tactics in authoritarian informationalism and show how these tactics are becoming more preventive, targeted, and less visible while not necessarily

less severe. Furthermore, the contributions illustrate the increasingly transnational nature of authoritarian practices and how they cut across regime types, also being applied by democratically elected governments. Overall, the articles provide important insights into the nature and limits of authoritarian informationalism and its implications for understanding and responding to the challenges posed by authoritarianism in the digital age.

Several avenues for future research emerge from the contributions to this Special Issue. First, while most of the contributions focus on authoritarian regimes, there is a need to further investigate the creeping of authoritarian practices into democracies. This includes examining how democratic governments use digital technologies to surveil, manipulate, and control information which goes beyond what this Special Issue has explored, as well as how these practices affect democratic institutions and processes in the long run. Apart from that, there is a need to further explore the transnational dimension of digital authoritarianism. This includes examining how authoritarian regimes seek to influence governance elsewhere, how successful they are in doing so, as well as how they cooperate with each other to share practices of authoritarian informationalism and technologies. Last but not least, while the role of AI in automating and scaling these tactics is not directly addressed in the contributions presented in this Special Issue, it is a pressing research agenda for the future. Understanding the implications of AI for democracy is crucial for comprehending and responding to the multifaceted challenges posed by authoritarian leaders in today's interconnected world.

Notes

1. Ruijgrok, "The Authoritarian Practice of Issuing Internet Shutdowns in India"; Eichhorn and Linhart, "Election-Related Internet-Shutdowns in Autocracies and Hybrid Regimes"; Lutscher, "When Censorship Works"; Chang and Lin, "Autocracy Login"; Rydzak et al., "Internet Shutdowns in Africa"; Freyburg and Garbe, "Authoritarian Practices in the Digital Age."
2. Lu and Pan, "Capturing Clicks"; Lutscher et al., "At Home and Abroad"; Roberts, *Censored*; King et al., "How the Chinese Government Fabricates Social Media Posts for Strategic Distraction, Not Engaged Argument."
3. Michaelsen, "Far Away, So Close."
4. Keremoglu and Weidmann, "How Dictators Control the Internet."
5. Earl et al., "The Digital Repression of Social Movements, Protest, and Activism."
6. Guriev and Treisman, "Informational Autocrats."
7. Michaelsen and Ruijgrok, "Digital Authoritarianism."
8. Schlumberger et al., "How Authoritarianism Transforms."
9. Guriev and Treisman, "Informational Autocrats."
10. Ibid.
11. Castells, *Network Society*.
12. Castells, *Social Movements and the Informational City*; Castells, *Network Society*.
13. Jiang "Authoritarian Informationalism."
14. Ibid."
15. Polyakova and Meserole, "Exporting Digital Authoritarianism"; Lilkov, "Made in China."
16. Guriev and Treisman, "Informational Autocrats."
17. Thanks to Kris Ruijgrok for pointing this out.
18. Glasius, "What Authoritarianism Is ... And Is Not."
19. For example, Guriev and Treisman, "Informational Autocrats"; Kendall-Taylor et al., "The Digital Dictators."
20. For example, Russia meddling with US elections or spreading disinformation in Germany, Ziegler, "International Dimensions of Electoral Processes"; Yarova, "Thematic Patterns of Russian Disinformation"; or transnational DoS attacks, Lutscher et al., "At Home and Abroad."

21. Human Rights Watch, *Guinea*.
22. Deibert, "Subversion Inc."
23. *Ibid.*, 31.
24. Schlumberger et al., "How Authoritarianism Transforms."
25. Wintrobe, "The Tinpot and the Totalitarian"; Kuran, *Private Truths, Public Lies*.
26. Xu, "To Repress or to Co-opt?"
27. Maerz, "The Electronic Face of Authoritarianism," 734.
28. Liang et al., "Constructing a Data-Driven Society," 416.
29. Garbe et al., "From Threat to Advocacy."
30. Powell, "The Good, the Bad, and the Ugly."
31. Cebul and Pinckney, *Digital Authoritarianism and Nonviolent Action*.
32. Zalnieriute, "Protests and Public Space Surveillance."
33. Allie, "Facial Recognition Technology and Voter Turnout"; Garbe et al., "Who Wants to Be Legible?"; Carson and Gibbons, "The Big Chill?," 24.
34. Qin et al., "Why Does China Allow Freer Social Media?"
35. Gerschewski, "The Three Pillars of Stability," 22.
36. Michaelsen, "Exit and Voice in a Digital Age"; Michaelsen, "Far Away, So Close."
37. Michaelsen and Anstis, "Gender-Based Digital Transnational Repression and the Authoritarian Targeting of Women in the Diaspora."
38. The article by Michaelsen and Anstis, "Gender-Based Digital Transnational Repression and the Authoritarian Targeting of Women in the Diaspora" was originally part of the Special Issue and substantially informs our argument about the scope of surveillance and control in the digital era.
39. Starbird et al., "Influence and Improvisation."
40. Osmundsen et al., "Partisan Polarization Is the Primary Psychological Motivation Behind Political Fake News Sharing on Twitter."
41. For example, Acemoglu et al., "A Model of Online Misinformation"; Van Bavel et al., "How Social Media Shapes Polarization"; Del Vicario et al., "The Spreading of Misinformation Online."
42. Munger et al., "Elites Tweet to Get Feet Off the Streets."
43. Woolley, "Digital Propaganda."
44. Schlumberger et al., "How Authoritarianism Transforms," 776.
45. Roberts, "Resilience to Online Censorship," 402.
46. For example, Vaccari and Chadwick, "Deepfakes and Disinformation."
47. Stukal et al., "Why Botter."
48. Alieva and Carley, "Internet Trolls Against Russian Opposition."
49. Linvill et al., "'The Russians Are Hacking My Brain!'"
50. Cirone and Hobbs, "Asymmetric Flooding as a Tool for Foreign Influence on Social Media."
51. Tomar et al., "The Role of AI-Driven Tools in Shaping the Democratic Process."
52. *Deutsche Welle*, "AI Fakes, Cyberattacks Threaten German Election."
53. Diakopoulos and Johnson, "Anticipating and Addressing the Ethical Implications of Deepfakes in the Context of Elections."
54. Monaco, "Digital Democracy Meets Automated Autocracy."
55. Howard et al., "Computational Propaganda," 48.
56. Freyburg et al., "The Political Power of Internet Business."
57. For example, Obadare, *Twitter Ban Shows Limits of State Power in Nigeria Council on Foreign Relations*.
58. For example, Plaum, "The Impact of Forced Data Localisation on Fundamental Rights."
59. King et al., "How Censorship in China Allows Government Criticism But Silences Collective Expression."
60. For example, Garbe, "Pulling Through Elections by Pulling the Plug."
61. Freyburg and Garbe, "Authoritarian Practices in the Digital Age"; Gohdes, "Pulling the Plug."
62. Roberts, *Censored*.
63. King et al., "How Censorship in China Allows Government Criticism But Silences Collective Expression."
64. Lutscher et al., "At Home and Abroad"; Lutscher, "When Censorship Works."

65. Garbe et al., “How African Countries Respond to Fake News and Hate Speech”; Cho, “Illiberal Responses to ‘Fake News’ in Southeast Asia”; Sombatpoonsiri and Luong, *Justifying Digital Repression via “Fighting Fake News”*.
66. Kendall-Taylor et al., “The Digital Dictators.”
67. See also Guriev and Treisman, “Informational Autocrats.”
68. Schmidt-Feuerheerd, “Collaborative Authoritarianism and Its Unintended Consequences.”
69. Burkhardt and Dollbaum, “Digital Ballots, Partisan Bias.”
70. Garbe et al., “Authoritarian Collaboration and Repression in the Digital Age.”
71. Conduit, “The Political Economy of Digital Authoritarianism.”
72. Sombatpoonsiri et al., “Ramping Up Control.”
73. Schumann, “Legalizing Control.”
74. Maerz, “How Practices of Digital Authoritarianism Harm Democracy”. The article by Michael-
sen and Anstis, “Gender-Based Digital Transnational Repression and the Authoritarian Target-
ing of Women in the Diaspora” was originally part of the Special Issue and substantially
informs our argument about the shift of authoritarian strategies from local to global arenas.
75. Schmidt-Feuerheerd, “Collaborative Authoritarianism and Its Unintended Consequences.”
76. Ibid., 3.
77. Burkhardt and Dollbaum, “Digital Ballots, Partisan Bias.”
78. Ibid., 14.
79. Burkhardt and Dollbaum, “Digital Ballots, Partisan Bias.”
80. Conduit, “The Political Economy of Digital Authoritarianism.”
81. Ibid., 11.
82. Ibid., 12.
83. Garbe et al., “Authoritarian Collaboration and Repression in the Digital Age.”
84. Sombatpoonsiri et al., “Ramping Up Control.”
85. Ibid., 2.
86. Schumann, “Legalizing Control.”
87. Maerz, “How Practices of Digital Authoritarianism Harm Democracy.”
88. Ibid.

Acknowledgements

We would like to thank the authors of the contributions to this Special Issue for their valuable insights and articles, and Marcus Michaelsen, Kris Ruijgrok, and Maurice Schumann for their helpful comments on this introduction. We also thank the editors of *Democratization* for their support in bringing this Special Issue together. The Special Issue builds on the fruitful discussions we had during the ECPR General Conference in Prague in 2023, where we organized a section on the topic of digital authoritarianism. We are grateful to all participants for their valuable contributions and insights. Seraphine F. Maerz received funding by the German Research Foundation, project number 421517935.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Funding

This work was supported by Deutsche Forschungsgemeinschaft: [Grant Number 421517935].

Notes on contributors

Lisa Garbe is a Research Fellow at the Institutions and Political Inequality Unit at the WZB Berlin Social Science Center. Her work explores how digitalization affects core democratic institutions such as elections and shapes government-citizen relationships.

Seraphine F. Maerz is a Senior Lecturer at the School of Social and Political Science of the University of Melbourne, Australia. Her work focuses on the comparative study of political regimes in the digital age and political communication.

References

- Acemoglu, Daron, Asuman Ozdaglar, and James Siderius. "A Model of Online Misinformation." *Review of Economic Studies* 91, no. 6 (2024): 3117–3150. doi:[10.1093/restud/rdad111](https://doi.org/10.1093/restud/rdad111).
- Alieva, Iuliia, and Kathleen M Carley. "Internet Trolls Against Russian Opposition: A Case Study Analysis of Twitter Disinformation Campaigns Against Alexei Navalny." *2021 IEEE International Conference on Big Data (Big Data)*, IEEE, 2021, 2461–2469.
- Allie, Feyaad. "Facial Recognition Technology and Voter Turnout." *The Journal of Politics* 85, no. 1 (2023): 328–333. doi:[10.1086/722039](https://doi.org/10.1086/722039).
- Burkhardt, Fabian, and Jan Matti Dollbaum. "Digital Ballots, Partisan Bias: Digital Authoritarianism and Support for Internet Voting in Russia, Belarus, and Ukraine." *Democratization* (2025): 1–22. doi:[10.1080/13510347.2025.2464149](https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2025.2464149).
- Carson, Andrea, and Andrew Gibbons. "The Big Chill? How Journalists and Sources Perceive and Respond to Fake News Laws in Indonesia and Singapore." *Journalism Studies* 24, no. 14 (2023): 1819–1838. doi:[10.1080/1461670X.2023.2192299](https://doi.org/10.1080/1461670X.2023.2192299).
- Castells, Manuel. *Network Society: A Theoretical Blueprint*. 2004.
- Castells, Manuel. *Social Movements and the Informational City*. 1989.
- Cebul, Matthew, and Jonathan C Pinckney. *Digital Authoritarianism and Nonviolent Action: Challenging the Digital Counterrevolution*. JSTOR, 2021.
- Chang, Chun Chih, and Thung Hong Lin. "Autocracy Login: Internet Censorship and Civil Society in the Digital age." *Democratization* 27, no. 5 (2020): 874–895. doi:[10.1080/13510347.2020.1747051](https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2020.1747051).
- Cho, Clare S. M. "Illiberal Responses to 'Fake News' in Southeast Asia." *Democratization* 32, no. 5 (2025): 1091–1111. doi:[10.1080/13510347.2024.2442395](https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2024.2442395).
- Cirone, Alexandra, and William Hobbs. "Asymmetric Flooding as a Tool for Foreign Influence on Social Media." *Political Science Research and Methods* 11, no. 1 (2023): 160–171. doi:[10.1017/psrm.2022.9](https://doi.org/10.1017/psrm.2022.9).
- Conduit, Dara. "The Political Economy of Digital Authoritarianism: Evidence from the Iranian Regime's Implementation of Technology." *Democratization* (2025): 1–23. doi:[10.1080/13510347.2025.2514766](https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2025.2514766).
- Deibert, Ronald J. "Subversion Inc: The Age of Private Espionage." *Journal of Democracy* 33, no. 2 (2022): 28–44. doi:[10.1353/jod.2022.0016](https://doi.org/10.1353/jod.2022.0016).
- Del Vicario, Michela, Alessandro Bessi, Fabiana Zollo, Fabio Petroni, Antonio Scala, Guido Caldarelli, H. Eugene Stanley, and Walter Quattrociocchi. "The Spreading of Misinformation Online." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 113, no. 3 (2016): 554–559. doi:[10.1073/pnas.1517441113](https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1517441113).
- Deutsche, Welle. *AI Fakes, Cyberattacks Threaten German Election*. 2024. <https://www.dw.com/en/from-ai-fakes-to-cyberattacks-threats-to-german-elections/a-70972702>.
- Diakopoulos, Nicholas, and Deborah Johnson. "Anticipating and Addressing the Ethical Implications of Deepfakes in the Context of Elections." *New Media & Society* 23, no. 7 (2021): 2072–2098. doi:[10.1177/1461444820925811](https://doi.org/10.1177/1461444820925811).
- Earl, Jennifer, Thomas V Maher, and Jennifer Pan. "The Digital Repression of Social Movements, Protest, and Activism: A Synthetic Review." *Science Advances* 8, no. 10 (2022): eabl8198. doi:[10.1126/sciadv.abl8198](https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.abl8198).
- Eichhorn, Kristin, and Eric Linhart. "Election-related Internet-Shutdowns in Autocracies and Hybrid Regimes." *Journal of Elections, Public Opinion and Parties* 33, no. 4 (2023): 705–725. doi:[10.1080/17457289.2022.2090950](https://doi.org/10.1080/17457289.2022.2090950).
- Freyburg, Tina, and Lisa Garbe. "Authoritarian Practices in the Digital Age| Blocking the Bottleneck: Internet Shutdowns and Ownership at Election Times in Sub-Saharan Africa." *International Journal of Communication* 12 (2018): 21.
- Freyburg, Tina, Lisa Garbe, and Véronique Wavre. "The Political Power of Internet Business: A Comprehensive Dataset of Telecommunications Ownership and Control (TOSCO)." *The Review of International Organizations* 18, no. 3 (2023): 573–600. doi:[10.1007/s11558-022-09483-z](https://doi.org/10.1007/s11558-022-09483-z).
- Garbe, Lisa. "Pulling Through Elections by Pulling the Plug: Internet Disruptions and Electoral Violence in Uganda." *Journal of Peace Research* 61, no. 5 (2024): 842–857. doi:[10.1177/00223433231168190](https://doi.org/10.1177/00223433231168190).
- Garbe, Lisa, Seraphine F. Maerz, and Tina Freyburg. "Authoritarian Collaboration and Repression in the Digital age: Balancing Foreign Direct Investment and Control in Internet Infrastructure." *Democratization* (2025): 1–24. doi:[10.1080/13510347.2024.2442377](https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2024.2442377).

- Garbe, Lisa, Nina McMurry, Alexandra Scacco, and Kelly Zhang. "Who Wants to Be Legible? Digitalization and Intergroup Inequality in Kenya." *Comparative Political Studies* 58, no. 9 (2024): 1803–1853. doi:[10.1177/00104140241276971](https://doi.org/10.1177/00104140241276971).
- Garbe, Lisa, Daniel Mwesigwa, and Toussaint Nothias. "From Threat to Advocacy." In *AI and Assembly: Coming Together and Apart in a Datafied World*, edited by Nothias Toussaint and Lucy Bernholz, 84–124. Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2025.
- Garbe, Lisa, Lisa-Marie Selvik, and Pauline Lemaire. "How African Countries Respond to Fake News and Hate Speech." *Information, Communication & Society* 26, no. 1 (2023): 86–103. doi:[10.1080/1369118X.2021.1994623](https://doi.org/10.1080/1369118X.2021.1994623).
- Gerschewski, Johannes. "The Three Pillars of Stability: Legitimation: Repression, and Co-Optation in Authoritarian Regimes." *Democratization* 20, no. 1 (2013): 13–38. doi:[10.1080/13510347.2013.738860](https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2013.738860).
- Glasius, Marlies. "What Authoritarianism is ... and is not: A Practice Perspective." *International Affairs* 94, no. 3 (2018): 515–533. doi:[10.1093/ia/iiy060](https://doi.org/10.1093/ia/iiy060).
- Gohdes, Anita R. "Pulling the Plug: Network Disruptions and Violence in Civil Conflict." *Journal of Peace Research* 52, no. 3 (2015): 352–367. doi:[10.1177/0022343314551398](https://doi.org/10.1177/0022343314551398).
- Guriey, Sergei, and Daniel Treisman. "Informational Autocrats." *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 33, no. 4 (2019): 100–127. doi:[10.1257/jep.33.4.100](https://doi.org/10.1257/jep.33.4.100).
- Howard, Philip, Fen Lin, and Viktor Tuzov. "Computational Propaganda: Concepts, Methods, and Challenges." *Communication and the Public* 8, no. 2 (2023): 47–53. doi:[10.1177/20570473231185996](https://doi.org/10.1177/20570473231185996).
- Human Rights Watch. *Guinea: Protect Phone Users' Privacy* Human Rights Watch. 2016. <https://www.hrw.org/news/2016/02/05/guinea-protect-phone-users-privacy>.
- Jiang, Min. "Authoritarian Informationalism: China's Approach to Internet Sovereignty." *SAIS Review of International Affairs* 30, no. 2 (2010): 71–89. doi:[10.1353/sais.2010.0006](https://doi.org/10.1353/sais.2010.0006).
- Kendall-Taylor, Andrea, Erica Frantz, and Joseph Wright. "The Digital Dictators: How Technology Strengthens Autocracy." *Foreign Affairs* 103, no. 1 (2020): 1–17.
- Keremoglu, Eda, and Nils B Weidmann. "How Dictators Control the Internet: A Review Essay." *Comparative Political Studies* 53, nos. 10–11 (2020): 1690–1703. doi:[10.1177/0010414020912278](https://doi.org/10.1177/0010414020912278).
- King, Gary, Jennifer Pan, and Margaret E. Roberts. "How Censorship in China Allows Government Criticism but Silences Collective Expression." *American Political Science Review* 107, no. 2 (2013): 326–343. doi:[10.1017/S0003055413000014](https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055413000014).
- King, Gary, Jennifer Pan, and Margaret E. Roberts. "How the Chinese Government Fabricates Social Media Posts for Strategic Distraction, Not Engaged Argument." *American Political Science Review* 111, no. 3 (2017): 484–501. doi:[10.1017/S0003055417000144](https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055417000144).
- Kuran, Timur. *Private Truths, Public Lies: The Social Consequences of Preference Falsification*. Cambridge, Massachusetts: Harvard University Press, 1998.
- Liang, Fan, Vishnupriya Das, Nadiya Kostyuk, and Muzammil M. Hussain. "Constructing a Data-Driven Society: China's Social Credit System as a State Surveillance Infrastructure." *Policy & Internet* 10, no. 4 (2018): 415–453. doi:[10.1002/poi3.183](https://doi.org/10.1002/poi3.183).
- Lilkov, Dimitar. "Made in China: Tackling Digital Authoritarianism." *European View* 19, no. 1 (2020): 110–110. doi:[10.1177/1781685820920121](https://doi.org/10.1177/1781685820920121).
- Linville, Darren L, Brandon C Boatwright, Will J. Grant, and Patrick L. Warren. "The Russians are Hacking My Brain! Investigating Russia's Internet Research Agency Twitter Tactics during the 2016 United States Presidential Campaign." *Computers in Human Behavior* 99 (2019): 292–300. doi:[10.1016/j.chb.2019.05.027](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.chb.2019.05.027).
- Lu, Yingdan, and Jennifer Pan. "Capturing Clicks: How the Chinese Government Uses Clickbait to Compete for Visibility." *Political Communication* 38, no. 1–2 (2021): 23–54. doi:[10.1080/10584609.2020.1765914](https://doi.org/10.1080/10584609.2020.1765914).
- Lutscher, Philipp M. "When Censorship Works: Exploring the Resilience of News Websites to Online Censorship." *British Journal of Political Science* 53, no. 4 (2022): 1342–1350.
- Lutscher, Philipp M., Nils B. Weidmann, Margaret E. Roberts, Mattijs Jonker, Alistair King, and Alberto Dainotti. "At Home and Abroad: The Use of Denial-of-Service Attacks During Elections in Nondemocratic Regimes." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 64, nos. 2–3 (2020): 373–401. doi:[10.1177/0022002719861676](https://doi.org/10.1177/0022002719861676).
- Maerz, Seraphine F. "How Practices of Digital Authoritarianism Harm Democracy." *Democratization* (2025): 1–28. doi:[10.1080/13510347.2025.2553826](https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2025.2553826).

- Maerz, Seraphine F. "The Electronic Face of Authoritarianism: E-Government as a Tool for Gaining Legitimacy in Competitive and Non-Competitive Regimes." *Government Information Quarterly* 33, no. 4 (2016): 727–735. doi:10.1016/j.giq.2016.08.008.
- Michaelsen, Marcus. "Exit and Voice in a Digital Age: Iran's Exiled Activists and the Authoritarian State." *Globalizations* 15, no. 2 (2018): 248–264. doi:10.1080/14747731.2016.1263078.
- Michaelsen, Marcus. "Far Away, So Close: Transnational Activism, Digital Surveillance and Authoritarian Control in Iran." *Surveillance & Society* 15, no. 3/4 (2017): 465–470. doi:10.24908/ss.v15i3/4.6635.
- Michaelsen, Marcus, and Siena Anstis. "Gender-Based Digital Transnational Repression and the Authoritarian Targeting of Women in the Diaspora." *Democratization* 32, no. 6 (2025): 1518–1540. doi:10.1080/13510347.2025.2476178.
- Michaelsen, Marcus, and Kris Ruijgrok. "Digital Authoritarianism." In *The Oxford Handbook of Authoritarian Politics*, edited by Anne Wolf. Oxford University Press, n.d. 2024. <https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/55828>
- Monaco, Nicholas J. "Digital Democracy Meets Automated Autocracy." In *Computational Propaganda: Political Parties, Politicians, and Political Manipulation on Social Media*, edited by Samuel C. Woolley, Philip N. Howard, 104–127. 2019.
- Munger, Kevin, Richard Bonneau, Jonathan Nagler, and Joshua A Tucker. "Elites Tweet to Get Feet Off the Streets: Measuring Regime Social Media Strategies During Protest." *Political Science Research and Methods* 7, no. 4 (2019): 815–834. doi:10.1017/psrm.2018.3.
- Obadare, Ebenezer. *Twitter Ban Shows Limits of State Power in Nigeria Council on Foreign Relations*. n.d. Accessed October 28, 2025. <https://www.cfr.org/blog/twitter-ban-shows-limits-state-power-nigeria>.
- Osmundsen, Mathias, Alexander Bor, Peter Bjerregaard Vahlstrup, Anja Bechmann, and Michael Bang Petersen. "Partisan Polarization Is the Primary Psychological Motivation Behind Political Fake News Sharing on Twitter." *American Political Science Review* 115, no. 3 (2021): 999–1015. doi:10.1017/S0003055421000290.
- Plaum, Alexander. "The Impact of Forced Data Localisation on Fundamental Rights." In *Access Now*. 2014. <https://www.accessnow.org/the-impact-of-forced-data-localisation-on-fundamental-rights/>.
- Polyakova, Alina, and Chris Meserole. "Exporting Digital Authoritarianism: The Russian and Chinese Models." *Policy Brief, Democracy and Disorder Series* (2019): 1–22. https://www.brookings.edu/wp-content/uploads/2019/08/FP_20190827_digital_authoritarianism_polyakova_meserole.pdf.
- Powell, Laura C. "The Good: The Bad, and the Ugly: Black Lives Matter Protests, the January 6th Insurrection, and Facial Recognition Technology as Admissible Evidence." *American University Law Review* 72 (2022): 277:335.
- Qin, Bei, David Strömberg, and Yanhui Wu. "Why Does China Allow Freer Social Media? Protests Versus Surveillance and Propaganda." *Journal of Economic Perspectives* 31, no. 1 (2017): 117–140. doi:10.1257/jep.31.1.117.
- Roberts, Margaret E. *Censored: Distraction and Diversion Inside China's Great Firewall*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2018.
- Roberts, Margaret E. "Resilience to Online Censorship." *Annual Review of Political Science* 23, no. 1 (2020): 401–419. doi:10.1146/annurev-polisci-050718-032837.
- Ruijgrok, Kris. "The Authoritarian Practice of Issuing Internet Shutdowns in India: The Bharatiya Janata Party's Direct and Indirect Responsibility." *Democratization* 29, no. 4 (2022): 611–633. doi:10.1080/13510347.2021.1993826.
- Rydzak, Jan, Moses Karanja, and Nicholas Opiyo. "Internet Shutdowns in Africa Dissent Does Not Die in Darkness: Network Shutdowns and Collective Action in African Countries." *International Journal of Communications* 14 (2020): 24–28. doi:10.46300/9107.2020.14.5.
- Schlumberger, Oliver, Mirjam Edel, Ahmed Maati, and Koray Saglam. "How Authoritarianism Transforms: A Framework for the Study of Digital Dictatorship." *Government and Opposition* 59, no. 3 (2024): 761–783. doi:10.1017/gov.2023.20.
- Schmidt-Feuerheerd, Bruno. "Collaborative Authoritarianism and its Unintended Consequences." *Democratization* (2024): 1–21. doi:10.1080/13510347.2024.2432018.
- Schumann, Maurice Phillip. "Legalizing Control: The Rise of Restrictive Internet Regulation in sub-Saharan Africa." *Democratization* (2025): 1–26. doi:10.1080/13510347.2025.2503370.
- Sombatpoonsiri, Janjira, and Dien Nguyen An Luong. *Justifying Digital Repression via "Fighting Fake News": A Study of Four Southeast Asian Autocracies*. Singapore: Published online by Cambridge University Press, 2022.

- Sombatpoonsiri, Janjira, Stephen Tyler Williams, and Kris Ruijgrok. "Ramping Up Control: How Judicial Harassment and Online Smear Campaigns Work in Tandem to Limit Dissent in Thailand." *Democratization* (2025): 1–28. doi:[10.1080/13510347.2025.2461478](https://doi.org/10.1080/13510347.2025.2461478).
- Starbird, Kate, Renée DiResta, and Matt DeButts. "Influence and Improvisation: Participatory Disinformation During the 2020 US Election." *Social Media and Society* 9, no. 2 (2023): 1–17. doi:[10.1177/20563051231177943](https://doi.org/10.1177/20563051231177943).
- Stukal, Denis, Sergey Sanovich, Richard Bonneau, and Joshua A. Tucker. "Why Botter: How Pro-Government Bots Fight Opposition in Russia." *American Political Science Review* 116, no. 3 (2022): 843–857. doi:[10.1017/S0003055421001507](https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055421001507).
- Tomar, Mayank, N. Raj, Shivani Singh, S. Marwaha, and Manish Tiwari. "The Role of Ai-Driven Tools in Shaping the Democratic Process: A Study of Indian Elections and Social Media Dynamics." *Industrial Engineering Journal* 52, no. 11 (2023): 143–153.
- Vaccari, Cristian, and Andrew Chadwick. "Deepfakes and Disinformation: Exploring the Impact of Synthetic Political Video on Deception, Uncertainty, and Trust in News." *Social Media+ Society* 6, no. 1 (2020): 2056305120903408. doi:[10.1177/2056305120903408](https://doi.org/10.1177/2056305120903408).
- Van Bavel, Jay J., Steve Rathje, Elizabeth Harris, Claire Robertson, and Anni Sternisko. "How Social Media Shapes Polarization." *Trends in Cognitive Sciences* 25, no. 11 (2021): 913–916. doi:[10.1016/j.tics.2021.07.013](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tics.2021.07.013).
- Wintrobe, Ronald. "The Tinpot and the Totalitarian: An Economic Theory of Dictatorship." *American Political Science Review* 84, no. 3 (1990): 849–872. doi:[10.2307/1962769](https://doi.org/10.2307/1962769).
- Woolley, Samuel C. "Digital Propaganda: The Power of Influencers." *Journal of Democracy* 33, no. 3 (2022): 115–129. doi:[10.1353/jod.2022.0027](https://doi.org/10.1353/jod.2022.0027).
- Xu, Xu. "To Repress or to Co-opt? Authoritarian Control in the Age of Digital Surveillance." *American Journal of Political Science* 65, no. 2 (2021): 309–325. doi:[10.1111/ajps.12514](https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12514).
- Yarova, Alla. "Thematic Patterns of Russian Disinformation." *Baltic Journal of Legal and Social Sciences* 4 (2023): 158–165. doi:[10.30525/2592-8813-2022-4-19](https://doi.org/10.30525/2592-8813-2022-4-19).
- Zalnieriute, Monika. "Protests and Public Space Surveillance: From Metadata Tracking to Facial Recognition Technologies (p. 9)." *Human Rights Council*. [Submission to the Thematic Report to the 50th Session of the Human Rights Council]. <https://Papers.Ssrn.Com/Sol3/Papers>. Cfm, 2021.
- Ziegler, Charles E. "International Dimensions of Electoral Processes: Russia, the USA, and the 2016 Elections." *International Politics* 55, no. 5 (2018): 557–574. doi:[10.1057/s41311-017-0113-1](https://doi.org/10.1057/s41311-017-0113-1).